



MEDINA FIGHT LAB PRESENTS

THE GLADIATOR'S SHOULDER

A 6-WEEK BIOMECHANICAL PROGRAM FOR COMBAT ATHLETES

Building explosive power, structural integrity, and punching durability.

MEDINA FIGHT LAB

WHY THIS PROGRAM EXISTS

THE FIGHTER'S DILEMMA

Since I started Muay Thai and working with combat athletes, I saw the same pattern over and over: fighters with shredded shoulders, chronic impingement, and careers cut short by injuries that should have been preventable.

The problem wasn't a lack of strength. It was a lack of **structural intelligence**. Fighters were bench pressing like bodybuilders while ignoring the scapulae, the rotator cuff, and the kinetic chain that actually delivers knockout power. A fighter's shoulder doesn't just push weight — it must:

- Explode through a kinetic chain to deliver knockout power
- Decelerate instantly to avoid hyperextension on a missed punch
- Endure torque from kimuras, whizzers, and clinch strikes
- Maintain a high guard without fatiguing the rotator cuff

That understanding led me to create this program. It's not about how much you can press — it's about building shoulders that can punch, clinch, defend, and last.

Let's get to work.

THE PUNCHING CHAIN

To understand why this program is structured the way it is, you must first understand what happens to your shoulder when you throw a punch.

THE KINETIC CHAIN

- **Phase 1 — Ground Reaction Force:** force travels up from the foot
- **Phase 2 — Rotational Torque:** hips and thoracic spine rotate
- **Phase 3 — Scapular Protraction:** the shoulder blade slides forward along the rib cage, maximizing reach
- **Phase 4 — Humerus Acceleration:** the rotator cuff stabilizes the humeral head while deltoid and triceps extend

THE DANGER ZONE: DECELERATION

The most dangerous phase of a punch is not the impact — it is the stop. When a punch lands or misses, the eccentric contraction of the rotator cuff and posterior deltoid must absorb massive force to prevent the arm from being ripped out of the socket. If these muscles are weak, the labrum tears and the bursa becomes inflamed.

"Train the decelerators to be stronger than the accelerators."

WHY SCAPULAE MATTER MORE THAN PECS

Most fighters suffer from "guard posture": rounded shoulders, forward head, and a closed chest. This posture impinges the supraspinatus tendon every time you raise your hand.

For healthy overhead motion, the glenohumeral joint and the scapulothoracic joint must move in a **2:1 ratio**. If your scapulae are weak:

- You lose up to 30% of your potential reach
- You grind the rotator cuff against the acromion (pinching)
- You transfer punching force to the elbow and wrist

THIS PROGRAM EMPHASIZES

- **Scapular retraction:** pulling the blades together (posture, health)
- **Scapular protraction:** reaching forward (punching length)
- **Scapular depression:** pulling the blades down (stability in the clinch)

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- **Frequency:** follow this program 3× per week for 6 weeks
- **Duration:** each session takes 30–45 minutes
- **When to train:** ideally 4–6 hours after technique work, or on active-recovery days
- **Warm up first:** never skip the 5–8 minute warm-up
- **Track progress:** use the weekly tracker at the end of this guide
- **Need help:** if you feel stuck or have pain, reach out — I'm here to help

PERIODIZATION OVERVIEW

1 FOUNDATION & MOTOR CONTROL

WEEKS 1–2

FOCUS MOTOR CONTROL & CUFF ACTIVATION

LOAD LIGHT (TEMPO 3-0-1)

2 STRENGTH & STABILITY

WEEKS 3–4

FOCUS STRENGTH & JOINT STABILITY

LOAD MODERATE (INTENT)

3 POWER & EXPLOSIVENESS

WEEKS 5–6

FOCUS POWER & EXPLOSIVENESS

LOAD MODERATE-HEAVY (VELOCITY)

FOUNDATION & CONTROL

WEEKS 1-2 • FOCUS: MOTOR CONTROL & CUFF ACTIVATION • LOAD: LIGHT

Wake up the scapula. Teach the rotator cuff how to stabilize. Correct posture. Perform all 6 exercises each session.

1 BANDED WALL ANGELS

FOCUS SCAPULAR RHYTHM & SUBACROMIAL SPACE

SETS & REPS 3 × 10

Re-educates scapular rhythm. Keeping the lower back flat against the wall while maintaining band tension forces the thoracic spine to extend and the scapulae to retract properly, keeping the subacromial space open when the arm goes overhead — preventing impingement.

CUES

- "Squeeze the orange" between shoulder blades
- "Wrists to the wall" — maintain contact throughout
- "Ribs down" — no arching of the lower back

2 PRONE Y-T-W-L

FOCUS LOWER/MIDDLE TRAPS, RHOMBOIDS, EXTERNAL ROTATORS

SETS & REPS 3 × 6 EACH POSITION

Isolates the lower trapezius (Y), middle trapezius (T), rhomboids (W) and external rotators (L). The lower traps are the anchor that depresses the humeral head during punching — without them the humerus rides up and pinches the cuff.

CUES

- "Thumbs up" before lifting
- Y: "Pocket to pocket"
- T: "Break the bar"
- W: "Elbows to hips"
- L: "Pour the pitcher"

3 HALF-KNEELING BAND PRESS

FOCUS ANTI-ROTATION STABILITY & CLINCH POSTING

SETS & REPS 3 × 10 PER ARM

The band pulls you into rotation; you resist with the core and stabilize the glenohumeral joint. This mimics the closed-chain stability needed in a clinch where one arm posts while the other strikes.

CUES

- "Screw the feet" into the floor
- "Proud chest, ribs down"
- "Finish with the scap" — protract fully at the end

4 CUBAN ROTATIONS

FOCUS SUPRASPINATUS & INFRASPINATUS (HOOKS/UPPERCUTS)

SETS & REPS 3 × 12

Directly targets the supraspinatus and infraspinatus — the muscles that protect the shoulder when throwing hooks and uppercuts.

CUES

- "Paint the wall" with elbows fixed in space
- "Rotate to the sky" — thumbs driving up
- "No elbow drop" — maintain height throughout

5 PRONE REVERSE FLY (THUMBS OUT)

FOCUS POSTERIOR DELTOID DECELERATORS

SETS & REPS 3 × 15

Head supported, thumbs rotated upward. Strengthens the posterior deltoid and rotator cuff — the decelerators. A strong posterior cuff is the only thing stopping your arm from hyperextending when you miss a punch.

CUES

- "Thumbs to the ceiling"
- "Lead with the elbows" — not the hands
- "Squeeze the marble" between shoulder blades
- "Slow descent" — 3 seconds down

6 DEAD HANG

FOCUS JOINT DECOMPRESSION & LAT STRETCH

SETS & REPS 2 × 45 SECONDS

Passive to active hang. Decompresses the glenohumeral joint and stretches the lats. Tight lats restrict overhead mobility and pull the humerus into internal rotation, ruining punching form.

CUES

- Passive: "Let the ears swim" — relax shoulders toward ears
- Active: "Armpits forward" — depress scapulae without bending arms
- Steady diaphragmatic breathing throughout — no breath holding

STRENGTH & STABILITY

WEEKS 3-4 • FOCUS: STRENGTH & JOINT STABILITY • LOAD: MODERATE

Increase load tolerance. Prepare for explosive movement. Perform all 6 exercises each session.

1 KETTLEBELL BOTTOM-UP CARRY

FOCUS REFLEXIVE ROTATOR CUFF STABILITY**SETS & REPS** 3 × 30 SEC PER ARM

Holding a kettlebell upside down forces reflexive stability — the shoulder must fire the cuff dynamically to keep the bell from wobbling. This mimics the micro-adjustments needed to hold a tight guard while moving.

CUES

- "Knuckles to the ceiling" — bell stays vertical
- "The laser pointer" — keep the bell perfectly still
- "Stack the joints" — wrist over elbow over shoulder

2 LANDMINE PRESS

FOCUS NEUTRAL-GRIP PUNCHING POWER**SETS & REPS** 4 × 8 PER ARM

Unlike a barbell bench press (which forces internal rotation), the neutral-grip landmine press allows natural scapular movement and external rotation. It builds punching power without grinding the cuff.

CUES

- "Pack the shoulder" before pressing
- "Bend the bar" toward centerline to engage lats
- "Finish with the scap" — protract at top

3 INVERTED ROW (SCAPULAR FOCUS)

FOCUS BALANCE PUSHING DOMINANCE**SETS & REPS** 4 × 10-12

Fighters are notoriously pushing-dominant. Rows balance the force couple between the anterior and posterior shoulder. A strong scapular retractor prevents the shoulders collapsing forward when fatigued in later rounds.

CUES

- "Plank the body" — no sagging hips
- "Scapular set" first without bending arms
- "Pause at the peak" for 2 seconds

4 FACE PULL WITH EXTERNAL ROTATION

FOCUS EXTERNAL ROTATION & THORACIC EXTENSION

SETS & REPS 3 × 15

The single best exercise for external-rotation strength and thoracic extension. It directly counters the hunched guard posture that plagues combat athletes.

CUES

- "Elbows high" — above the hands throughout
- "Thumbs back" at end range
- "Open the chest" to the ceiling

5 PLYOMETRIC CLAP PUSH-UP

FOCUS STRETCH-SHORTENING CYCLE FOR POWER

SETS & REPS 3 × 5-8

Trains the stretch-shortening cycle (SSC) of the pecs and triceps. Punching power relies on the SSC — the quick eccentric loading of the muscles before the concentric explosion.

CUES

- "Loaded spring" on descent
- "Explode" with maximum velocity
- "Soft catch" — land with elbows slightly bent

6 SUITCASE CARRY

FOCUS LAT ENGAGEMENT & CORE STABILITY

SETS & REPS 3 × 45 SEC PER SIDE

Targets the latissimus dorsi and quadratus lumborum. The lat is the bridge between the core and the shoulder — a strong lat transfers rotational torque from the hips to the fist.

CUES

- "Anti-sidebend" — no leaning
- "Pack the shoulder" — no shrugging
- "Active grip" — squeeze the handle hard

POWER & EXPLOSIVENESS

WEEKS 5-6 • FOCUS: POWER & EXPLOSIVENESS • LOAD: MODERATE-HEAVY

Transfer stability into ballistic, fight-specific velocity. Perform all 6 exercises each session.

1 SINGLE-ARM KETTLEBELL JERK

FOCUS KINETIC CHAIN SYNCHRONIZATION

SETS & REPS 4 × 6 PER ARM

Mimics the kinetic chain of a punch better than any barbell lift. It requires triple extension (ankle, knee, hip) followed by a punch of the bell overhead — training the synchronization of lower-body power with upper-body delivery.

CUES

- "Dip and drive" with the legs
- "Punch through" the handle
- "Ear hole" — bicep by ear in lockout

2 MED BALL SLAM (ROTATIONAL)

FOCUS ROTATIONAL POWER FOR HOOKS

SETS & REPS 3 × 8 PER SIDE

Directly mimics a hook. It forces the serratus anterior (the boxer's muscle) to protract the scapula violently while the core rotates — building knockout power in hooks and uppercuts.

CUES

- "Load the hip" before rotating
- "Punch and protract" at impact
- "Quiet upper body" — power from the hips

3 ARCHER PUSH-UPS

FOCUS TENDON DENSITY & ECCENTRIC CONTROL

SETS & REPS 3 × 8 PER ARM

A regression toward one-arm push-up strength. It places high eccentric stress on the loaded shoulder, building the tendon density and stability required for grappling and posting on the mat.

CUES

- "Shift the weight" over one arm
- "Eccentric control" — 3 seconds down
- "The bow" shape — body forms a bow

4 BANDED SCAPULAR PUNCHES

FOCUS SERRATUS ANTERIOR ACTIVATION

SETS & REPS 3 × 20 (FAST)

Isolates the serratus anterior. When it is weak, the scapula wings off the rib cage, causing inefficient force transfer and instability. This teaches the scapula to slide forward with the punch to maximize reach.

CUES

- "Punch and reach" — focus on ribcage expansion
- "The slide" — scapula moving fully forward
- Speed drill — fast reps, full range

5 EXTERNAL ROTATION CATCH

FOCUS REACTIVE ROTATOR CUFF STRENGTH

SETS & REPS 3 × 10 PER ARM

Plyometric training for the rotator cuff. In a fight you don't know when impact will come — this trains the reflexive stiffness of the cuff to absorb unexpected force, like a punch landing on your glove or defending a takedown.

CUES

- "Reflex catch" — no pre-tensing
- Stay relaxed until the drop
- Partner controls the weight — start light

6 FARMER'S WALK (HEAVY)

FOCUS SCAPULAR DEPRESSION ENDURANCE

SETS & REPS 3 × 30 SECONDS

Builds scapular depression (pulling the blades down). In grappling, if your scapulae elevate you lose neck protection and are easier to manipulate. Heavy carries build the endurance to keep shoulders down and back for three rounds.

CUES

- "Scapular pockets" — blades tucked down
- "Crush the handle" — aggressive grip
- "No shrug" — if shoulders creep up, drop the weight

THE WARM-UP

5–8 minutes. Perform before every session.

CAT-COW STRETCH

10 REPS

Purpose: Mobilize the thoracic spine

- "String of pearls" — move one vertebra at a time
- Inhale cow (belly drops, chest opens)
- Exhale cat (spine rounds, chin tucks)

THREAD THE NEEDLE

5 REPS PER SIDE

Purpose: Open thoracic rotation

- "Reach through the tunnel" — feel the stretch between the blades
- Hold 2–3 breaths per side

BAND PULL-APARTS

20 REPS (HIGH, MID, LOW GRIP)

Purpose: Activate rhomboids & external rotators

- "Break the band" across the chest
- Keep arms straight
- Vary grip width: narrow, shoulder-width, wide

SLEEPER STRETCHES

30 SECONDS PER SIDE

Purpose: Maintain internal-rotation flexibility

- "Push the hand down" with the opposite hand
- Keep the blade tucked — don't let it wing off the rib cage

SCAPULAR PUSH-UPS

15 REPS

Purpose: Wake up the serratus anterior

- "Protract to round" — push the floor away, upper back rounds slightly
- "Retract to squeeze" — let the chest sink, squeeze the blades together

PROGRAMMING

INTEGRATION WITH FIGHT TRAINING

IN-SEASON (FIGHT CAMP)

Reduce to 2 days per week (weeks 5–6). Maintain explosive work, reduce accessory volume. Perform after technique, never before sparring.

OFF-SEASON (BUILDING PHASE)

Full 3 days per week. Progress weight only when form is perfect. Use this time to build structural capacity.

TIMING

Ideally perform 4–6 hours after technical training, or on active-recovery days.

Do not: perform this program immediately before heavy-bag work or sparring · ignore sharp pain · skip the warm-up.

INJURY CHECK-IN

When to push. When to pause. When to reach out.

MILD MUSCLE SORENESS

Okay — stay the course. Normal after activation.

SHARP PAIN DURING MOVEMENT

Stop immediately. Modify or skip that exercise.

PINCHING IN FRONT OF THE SHOULDER

Likely impingement. Check elbow position — keep it tucked, not flared.

PAINFUL ARC (60-120° ABDUCTION)

Stop overhead work. Focus on Phase 1 retraction drills.

LINGERING PAIN > 48 HOURS

Rest. Apply ice. Reach out if it persists.

NO IMPROVEMENT AFTER 6 WEEKS

Book a 1-on-1 call. Let's troubleshoot together.

Remember: this program is designed to build durability, not break you down. Pushing through sharp pain is not toughness — it's how careers end.

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 1

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 2

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 3

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 4

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 5

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

6-WEEK TRACKER — SESSION 6

#	EXERCISE	WEIGHT	SET 1	SET 2	SET 3	PAIN (0-10) / NOTES
1.						
2.						
3.						
4.						
5.						
6.						

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NEXT STEP

BOOK YOUR FREE STRATEGY CALL

You've put in the work — six weeks of building shoulders that can withstand the rigors of combat sports. If you:

- Want faster recovery or pain relief
- Are unsure what to do next
- Need help customizing this program for your specific shoulder issue
- Want to take your durability to the next level before a fight camp

I'M HERE FOR YOU. LET'S TALK.

Email & Instagram below — reach out and we'll build your plan.

medina.physio@gmail.com

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**TRAIN HARD.
TRAIN SMART.
BUILD DURABILITY.**

MEDINA FIGHT LAB